These self-correcting mechanisms are costly, but if you want to get the truth, you must invest in them.

Silicon Valley thought it was exempt from this historical rule. Social media platforms have been singularly lacking in self-correcting mechanisms. In 2014, Facebook employed just a single Burmese-speaking content moderator to monitor activities in the whole of Myanmar.[15] When observers in Myanmar began warning Facebook that it needed to invest more in moderating content, Facebook ignored them. For example, Pwint Htun, a Burmese American engineer and telecom executive who grew up in rural Myanmar, wrote to Facebook executives repeatedly about the danger. In an email from 5 July 2014 – two years before the ethnic-cleansing campaign began – she issued a prophetic warning: 'Tragically, FB in Burma is used like radio in Rwanda during the dark days of genocide.' Facebook took no action.

Even after the attacks on the Rohingya intensified and Facebook faced a storm of criticism, it still refused to hire people with expert local knowledge to curate content. Thus, when informed that hate-mongers in Myanmar were using the Burmese word *kalar* as a racist slur for the Rohingya, Facebook reacted in April 2017 by banning from the platform any posts that used the word. This revealed Facebook's utter lack of knowledge about local conditions and the Burmese language. In Burmese, *kalar* is a racist slur only in specific contexts. In other contexts, it is an entirely innocent term. The Burmese word for chair is *kalar htaing*, and the word for chickpea is *kalar pae*. As Pwint Htun wrote to Facebook in June 2017, banning the term *kalar* from the platform is like banning the letters 'hell' from 'hello'.[16] Facebook continued to ignore the need for local expertise. By April 2018, the number of Burmese speakers Facebook employed to moderate content for its eighteen million users in Myanmar was a grand total of five.[17]

Instead of investing in self-correcting mechanisms that would reward truth telling, the social media giants actually developed unprecedented error-enhancing mechanisms that rewarded lies and fictions. One such error-enhancing mechanism was the Instant Articles programme that Facebook rolled out in Myanmar in 2016. Wishing to drive up engagement, Facebook paid news channels according to the amount of user engagement they generated, measured in clicks and views. No importance whatsoever was given to the truthfulness of the 'news'. A 2021 study found that in 2015, before the programme was launched, six of the ten top Facebook